

SUMMER THEATER

Our top 10, from ‘42 Balloons’ to ‘Beauty and the Beast’ and Amy Morton at Steppenwolf



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SUNDAY, JUNE 1, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CASH CROPS, HIDDEN COSTS



WHO OWNS MOST OF THE FARMLAND IN ILLINOIS? NOT FARMERS

By Karina Atkins | Chicago Tribune

Surrounded by rows of soybeans and corn, Hans Bishop’s farm in central Illinois was an anomaly. He grew kale, peppers, eggplants and radishes, selling to Whole Foods from June through October and to local restaurants, grocers and families year-round. The vegetable farm was born in 2009 on a quarter acre rented to him by his father, a row crop farmer. After spending a decade in the corporate world, Bishop was inspired by documentaries such as “Fresh” and “Food, Inc.” that scrutinized conventional farming. He returned to the fields with aspirations to farm differently. The fresh produce Bishop grew landed directly on chopping boards and dinner plates. It wasn’t being funneled into gasoline tanks, ultra-processed foods or livestock feed troughs — the most common destinations for Illinois’ leading agricultural products, soybeans and corn. In less than a decade, his operation in Logan County had expanded to 80 acres. It was becoming what progressive food movements celebrate as “sustainable.” But he couldn’t keep it going. Bishop and his wife, Katie, spent countless hours on marketing, had to rely on hired labor and couldn’t access the federally subsidized safety nets available to commodity farmers.

Bishop, now 41, phased out his flourishing vegetable enterprise after his father abruptly retired in 2019, leaving him to take over the family bean and grain operation. Part of the land — 120 of the nearly 700 acres — is rented from a family who owns multiple farm properties and wants their fields weed-free with perfectly straight grids of crops, a deep-rooted tradition among Midwestern farming communities. “They want that land to be clean corn and soybeans,” Bishop said. Before the restrictions, his father was growing organic corn and soybeans on part of the field and letting Bishop grow vegetables on the rest. Now, to keep the fields to the owner’s standards, Bishop has had to forgo vegetables

Rain clouds pass over a cornfield owned by Farmland Reserve in Arrowsmith in central Illinois on Thursday. Farmland Reserve, a private Salt Lake City-based investment firm affiliated with the Mormon Church, is the largest farmland owner in Illinois. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/ CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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and use pesticides and fertilizers, which can pollute nearby water sources and degrade soil health over time. Less than a fourth of Illinois farmland is owned by the farmer who works the land, according to data from the Illinois Farm Business Farm Management, a nonprofit association that helps farmers make management decisions. The rest is leased to farmers by individuals, family trusts and, increasingly, businesses. The Tribune is launching a series of special reports analyzing the hurdles many farmers face in trying to be good stewards of the land as climate change intensifies. Among the chal-

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GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Spending cuts, tax hikes in proposal

Dems scramble to pass \$55B plan drawing cash from tobacco, betting

By Dan Petrella, Jeremy Gorner, Olivia Olander and Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — With only hours remaining before their midnight deadline, Democratic state lawmakers on Saturday night still were finalizing various components of a more than \$55 billion budget balanced with a combination of spending cuts and tax increases. The spending portion of the plan was unveiled late Friday, but a package of tax increases and other revenue measures didn’t surface until early Saturday evening. With less than three hours remaining to approve the package by a simple majority, no final votes had been taken. When the calendar turns to June, the threshold rises to a three-fifths majority. “This place, often on this day, we look towards what I call ... May 32, which doesn’t exist on a calendar in real life, but it will be a late night,” Rep. Kam Buckner of Chicago, a budget negotiator for House Democrats, said as closed-door discussions continued. “I’m optimistic it will get done.” Heading Gov. JB Pritzker’s warning that he would veto a plan that relied on increases to the state’s sales or income taxes, legislators were working through a package that would employ one-time tactics, such as an

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INSIDE



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cubs’ versatility fuels hot streak

Pete Crow-Armstrong, above, is a real star, the bullpen is falling into shape, and the Cubs have learned to win in a variety of ways, writes Paul Sullivan. **Chicago Sports**

Hamas submits its response to US plan

Hamas seeks amendments to the latest ceasefire plan for Gaza, but the U.S. balks at requests to make it permanent, and for the withdrawal of Israeli forces. **Nation & World**

Feds seek 12-plus years for Madigan

Prosecutors asked for a 12½-year sentence plus \$1.5 million fine for the ex-state House speaker, while the defense requested five years of probation. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Data shows few reported dog bites result in citations

Residents, officials say holding owners to account can be opaque

By Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

Ed Wolf doesn’t quite recall the moments between being knocked off his bike and losing a chunk of his face in November 2023. But he remembers the phone call he made to his wife: “I said, ‘You have to come get me. I’ve been attacked by a pit bull,’ ” Wolf said. “And she goes, ‘Are you kidding?’ ” A day and 50 stitches later Wolf, 68, went to the police

station to report the bite and found himself navigating a morass of different systems as he tried to draw official attention to the dog’s owner. An officer at the Morgan Park District (22nd) police station helped Wolf get started on a bite report, which kickstarts an investigation at Chicago Animal Care and Control. The city department received some 6,435 bite reports between January 2020 and April 30 of this year, according to a Tribune review of data obtained through a Freedom of Information Act request. For that same period, data

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Ed Wolf puts his bike helmet on before a bike ride in Chicago on Friday. In 2023, Wolf was knocked down and bitten in the face by a pit bull. When the dog attacked him, he was wearing these same sunglasses and helmet. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

